

reached the Administrative Control Panel (ACP) for your PHP-Nuke Web site. Now, before you can start building your site, you need to know what each little icon in your ACP means, and how you can leverage them within your site.

Since we cannot list all of them in detail, we will only cover the most important ones. You should be able to decipher the rest easily enough by clicking on them.

Preferences

This is where you set all the important settings of your site, such as the name of the site, the logo it uses, the theme or colour of the entire site, and all administrative information and settings.

Make sure to set all the correct information here first. You should also check out the different theme options that come bundled with PHP-Nuke and decide on one that suits your site best. You can always tweak the design later, or even download a PHP-Nuke theme from the thousands available online.

Blocks

Blocks are just that—blocks! The different boxes you see around the default site that you already have

are its blocks. We have marked out different blocks in boxes in the accompanying screenshot to better illustrate this. From the ACP, you can control which blocks are shown on your site, and more importantly, where on the site they appear.

You will see the following details mentioned: Title, Position, Weight, Type, Status, Visible To, and Functions with Edit, Activate/Deactivate, Delete and Show options. So, for example, let's say you want to move the Login block to the left of the Web site and disable the Languages block:

First, you click on the Edit icon in line with 'Languages'. In the new page that loads, you will see that you can change the option for Activate to 'No'. This will deactivate the Languages module, and you should also set the 'Visible to Subscribers' option to 'No', to hide the Languages block.

Now, just edit the Login block the same way, and just set the value of "Position" to "Left".

Now you can go ahead and play about with the blocks to see what you want where and what you want to remove. You can also create new blocks, with links to new pages that you construct. It's really very easy once you do it yourself.

Modules

Modules are like functions of your Web site, and can be controlled easily using the ACP. Clicking on the Modules link takes you to a page with a long list of modules. Here you have to choose what's important for your site to have and what isn't. Remember, there has to be at least one module linked to your home page.

By default, this is set to the News module, as PHP-Nuke was primarily built for community boards. You can change this to anything else, and you can also download and install more modules from the Net.

By default, the following modules are active after you install PHP-Nuke:

AvantGo, Downloads, Feedback, Journal, Private Messages, Recommend Us, Search, Statistics, Stories Archive, Submit News, Surveys, Top 10, Topics, Web Links, Your Account.

The easiest way to learn what each one is, is to click on the link and see where you go. It's all pretty straightforward.

Options

PHP-Nuke has many offshoots; as developers took up the challenge and started developing their own versions of easy-to-configure PHP-based sites. Here are a few examples, in case you'd rather try them out instead:

- PostNuke:** Based on PHP-Nuke 5.0; www.postnuke.com
- myPHPNuke:** Based on PHP-Nuke 4.4; www.myphpnuke.com
- Xaraya:** Based on PostNuke; www.xaraya.com
- NPDS:** Based on PHP-Nuke 4.3; <http://www.npds.org/us>
- XOOPS:** Based on myPHP-Nuke; www.xoops.org
- PHP-Nuke Platinum:** PHP-Nuke, but with a lot more modules thrown in to help skip searching for them online; http://snipurl.com/nuke_plat

Messages

The default message you see in your home page is listed here. Messages are sort of like posts that get priority over everything else in the home page. They can be set to be permanent, such as an introduction to your site, or temporary, such as informing site visitors that the downloads section will be down for a week. You can also have messages only for registered users, or other administrators—basically different usergroups.

Investing The Time

Though this will only get you started with your Web site, PHP-Nuke is built to be easy to understand. Even if you do come across problems, or cannot understand something, there are hundreds of forums that discuss and solve any questions or problems that people face.

In the end, how well-designed and snazzy your site looks depends solely on the amount of time you can dedicate to it. You can also add a shopping cart and a payment gateway, and sell your goods online. The options are unlimited, especially with PHP-Nuke modules, which seem to be made for each and every function you could ever imagine.

Building your dream site is a lot easier now—all it takes is some time, the right keywords in Google, and a little bit of bandwidth! ■

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Each red box in this screenshot depicts one block



Manage your block placement from the ACP